PRESIDENCY DESK · BRIEF 2 OF 4

PESCO Strategic Review

What Ireland Should Lock In

The strategic review is rewriting PESCO's rules: what the binding commitments are, how compliance is assessed, and how PESCO connects to EU funding. Ireland's domain-specific model is either formalised as a permanent feature of EU defence cooperation — or penalised.

Security Ireland

June 2026

KEY FINDINGS

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PESCO is the only EU framework where Ireland's defence contribution is formally recognised. Ireland's 7 full-member projects — all targeting maritime, subsea, cyber, and logistics — are the institutional evidence that Ireland contributes to European security. The strategic review is rewriting PESCO's rules; if the revised framework rewards full-spectrum participation, Ireland's selective, domain-specific approach is penalised. However, if it recognises domain-specific excellence, Ireland's contribution is formalised permanently. Ireland chairs the Council where these rules are being decided. This brief identifies four actions that lock in Ireland's permanent role through the PESCO architecture.

The strategic objective

Ireland's strategic objective for the Presidency is to establish itself as a permanent, credible contributor to European security in the domains where its geography is irreplaceable — maritime surveillance, subsea infrastructure protection, and cyber resilience — so that when the Presidency ends in December 2026, Ireland has locked in a role that outlasts the political window.

This is not altruism; a permanent role means Ireland is no longer vulnerable to the free-rider accusation. It means EU funding instruments recognise Ireland's contribution. It means bilateral and EU partners have institutional reasons to cooperate with Ireland beyond the goodwill of any single government. The Presidency is the six-month window in which this can be achieved.

WHY PESCO MATTERS FOR THIS OBJECTIVE

PESCO is the only EU framework where Ireland's defence contribution is formally recognised. Ireland's 7 projects are the institutional evidence. The strategic review is rewriting the rules: what the binding commitments are, how compliance is assessed, and how PESCO connects to EU funding instruments. Ireland chairs the Council where these rules are decided. This is the mechanism through which Ireland's contribution is either formalised or marginalised.

What PESCO is

26	68	7	20
Participating member states	Ongoing projects	Ireland's full-member projects	Binding commitments under review

Figure 1: The PESCO framework. 26 participating member states, 68 collaborative projects, 20 binding commitments. The strategic review, launched November 2023, is rewriting the commitments for the 2026–2030 phase. Implementation falls during Ireland's Presidency.

The Permanent Structured Cooperation is the EU's framework for joint defence capability development. Launched in December 2017, it is distinguished from other EU defence cooperation by its legally binding commitments — participating states commit to increasing defence spending, investing jointly, and enhancing operational readiness. Twenty-six member states participate. Only Malta remains outside.

PESCO hosts 68 collaborative projects across six domains: training, land, maritime, air, cyber, and strategic enablers. The sixth wave, approved in May 2025, added 11 new projects including air and missile defence, electronic warfare doctrine, and quantum technology.

Ireland joined PESCO in 2017 and participates in seven projects as a full member, with observer status on seventeen more. The projects it chose are revealing: Upgrade of Maritime Surveillance, Maritime Semi-Autonomous Systems for Mine Countermeasures, Cyber Threats and Incident Response, Critical Seabed Infrastructure Protection, and Network of Logistic Hubs. Ireland has not joined tank programmes or fighter-jet consortia.

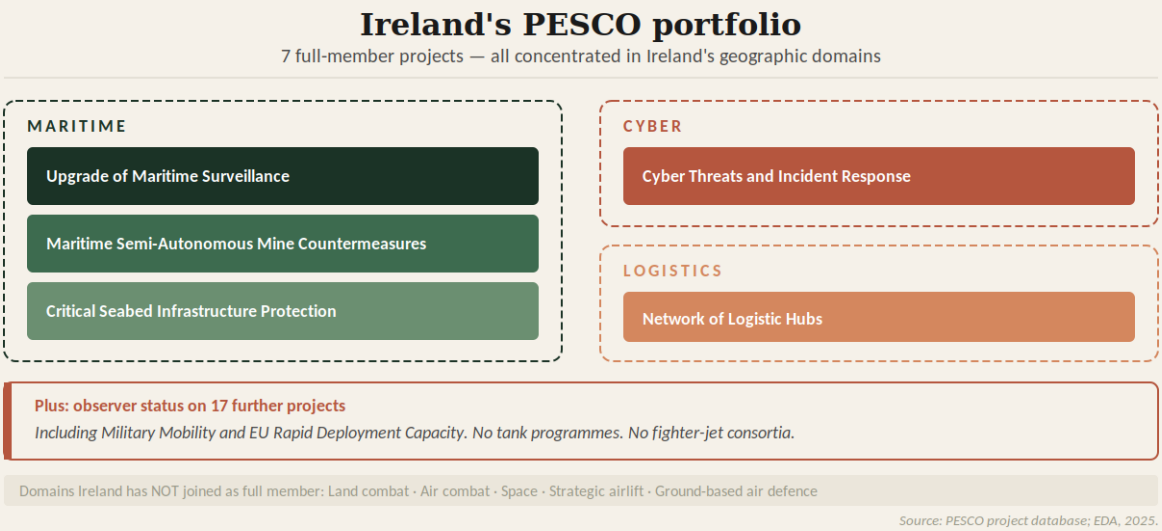

Figure 2: Ireland's PESCO portfolio. Seven full-member projects concentrated in maritime, cyber, and logistics — the domains where Ireland's geography is irreplaceable. No participation in land combat, air combat, or space projects.

PESCO — PERMANENT STRUCTURED COOPERATION

Established December 2017 under the Lisbon Treaty. 26 participating member states. 20 binding commitments covering defence spending, capability development, industrial cooperation, and operational readiness. The strategic review, launched November 2023, is rewriting these commitments for 2026–2030. The revised framework is expected to be operational during Ireland's Presidency.

What's being decided during Ireland's term

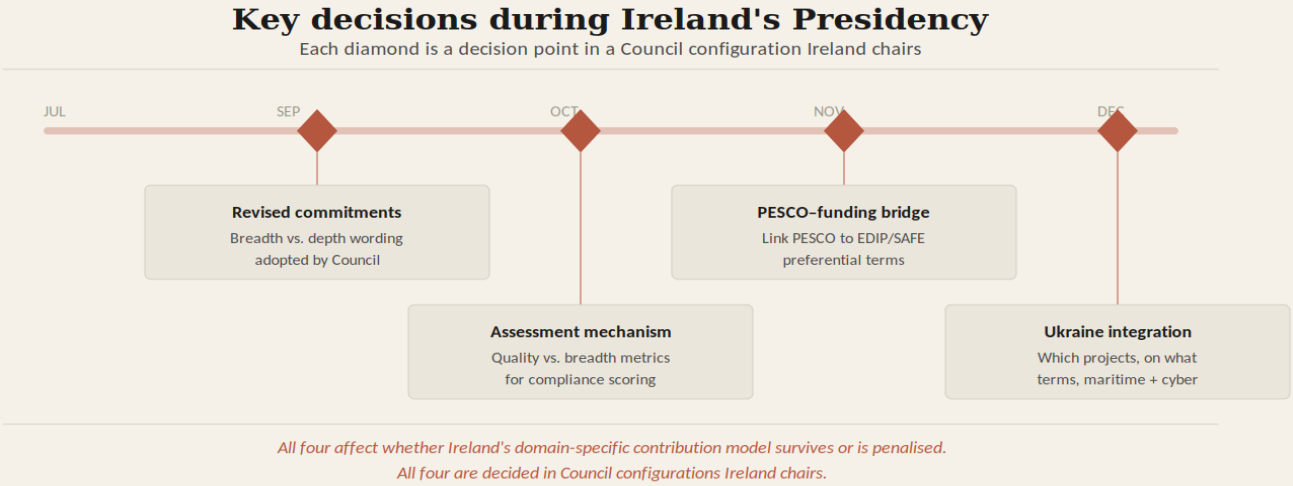

Figure 3: Key decisions during Ireland's Presidency term (July–December 2026). Each diamond represents a decision point in a Council configuration Ireland chairs. All four affect whether Ireland's domain-specific contribution model survives or is penalised.

1. The revised binding commitments

The 20 current commitments are being streamlined into a smaller set structured around four areas: (1) defence spending, (2) capability development, (3) industrial cooperation, and (4) the operational dimension. The specific wording — whether commitments require breadth or allow depth — determines whether Ireland's model works.

2. The assessment mechanism

How compliance is measured matters as much as what is committed to. If assessment rewards the number of domains a state participates in, Ireland scores poorly. If it assesses quality and strategic relevance, Ireland's maritime and cyber focus scores well.

3. The PESCO-EDIP-SAFE connection

The review calls for alignment between PESCO and EU funding instruments, but does not specify how. Whether active PESCO participation earns preferential access to EDIP grants or SAFE loans is still undefined.

4. Ukraine's integration

The Council's November 2024 conclusions stress bringing Ukraine closer to PESCO. Which projects, on what terms, is being decided during Ireland's Presidency.

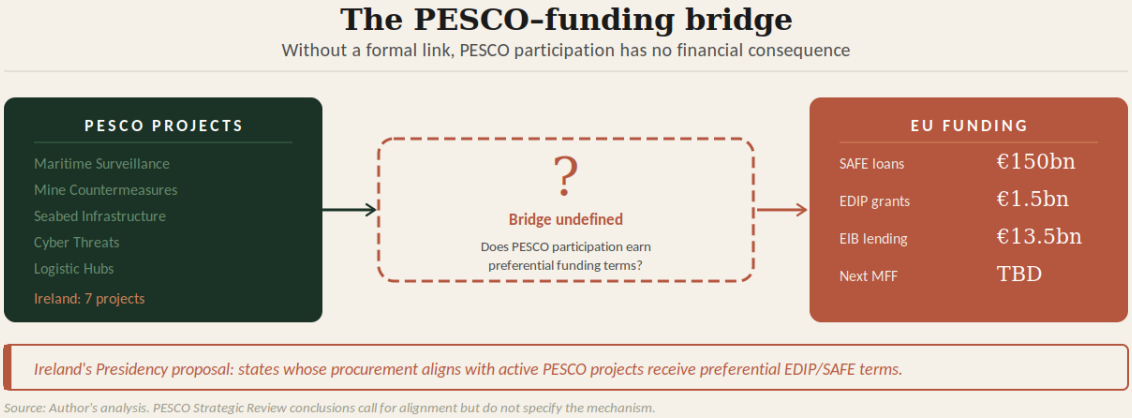

Figure 4: The PESCO–funding bridge. PESCO projects and EU funding instruments (SAFE, EDIP) currently operate in separate channels with no formal link. Ireland's Presidency can define the connection.

The problem the review is trying to solve

PESCO was launched with ambition: legally binding commitments that would drive real defence cooperation. But the binding commitments have been largely forgotten. Sixty-eight projects is too many for meaningful oversight, and the 2025 progress report found that roughly half would reach full operational capability on time.

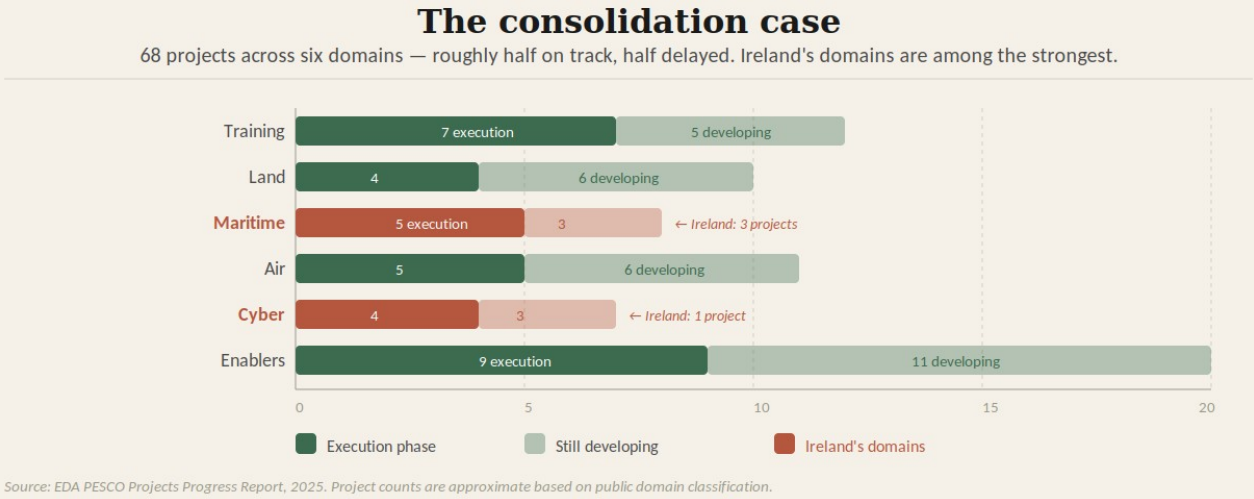

Figure 5: PESCO projects by domain and status. Roughly half have reached execution phase. Ireland's domains — maritime and cyber — have strong execution rates. Consolidation would concentrate resources on projects that deliver.

What Ireland should do

Four actions, each justified by how it advances the strategic objective of locking in Ireland's permanent security role in its geographic domains.

1. Ensure the revised commitments include a 'domain excellence' pathway

The new binding commitments must allow a member state to demonstrate compliance through deep, strategically relevant participation in specific domains rather than shallow participation across all domains. Ireland should draft the language.

Ireland's Presidency authority over Council working group agendas gives it direct influence over the drafting process. The High Representative was invited to propose amendments by May 2025. Ireland chairs the Council discussions that adopt the final text.

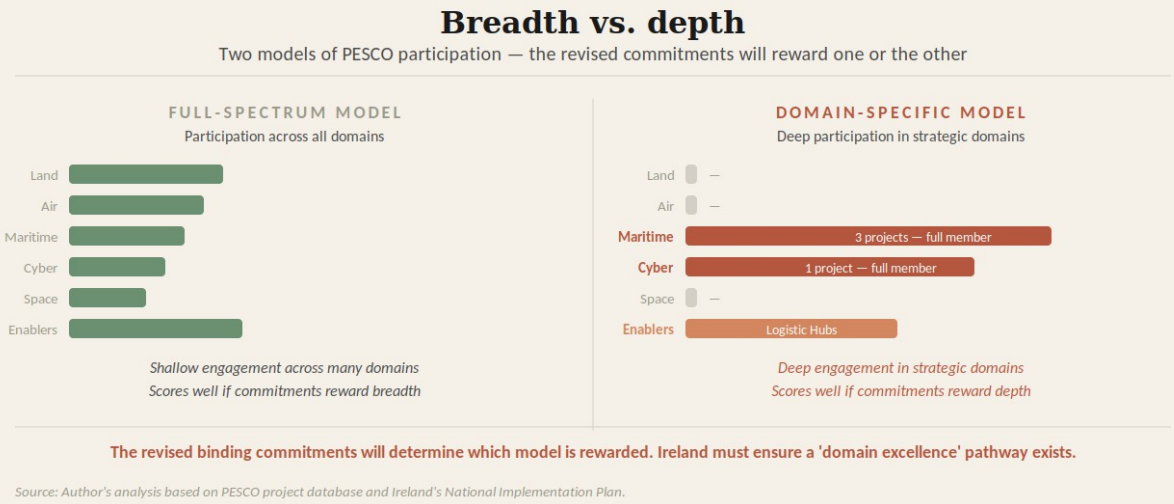

Figure 6: Two models of PESCO participation. The full-spectrum model spreads engagement across all domains. Ireland's domain-specific model concentrates on maritime, cyber, and logistics. The revised binding commitments will reward one or the other.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Ireland's maritime and cyber model as a recognised form of EU defence contribution, permanently.*

2. Propose that PESCO participation earns EDIP/SAFE preferential terms

This creates a financial bridge between Ireland's PESCO projects and EU funding instruments. If active PESCO participation earns preferential EDIP/SAFE terms, Ireland's projects become pipelines to EU defence funding.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *A permanent funding pathway for Ireland's domain-specific contribution.*

3. Push for consolidation of projects around capability delivery

Sixty-eight projects is too many. Ireland should push for the Council to recommend merging or closing projects that have not delivered. This concentrates resources on the projects that matter, including the maritime and cyber projects Ireland participates in.

> **THIS LOCKS IN:** *Stronger, better-funded projects in Ireland's domains.*

4. Advance Ukraine's participation in maritime and cyber projects

Ukraine has operational experience in counter-drone, electronic warfare, and cyber defence. Ireland can broker Ukraine's participation in the PESCO maritime and cyber projects it already belongs to — strengthening both the projects and Ireland's role as convener.

THIS LOCKS IN: *Ireland as the convener of the maritime/cyber PESCO community, not just a participant.*

What happens if Ireland doesn't act

The revised commitments demand full-spectrum participation. Ireland's domain-specific model is assessed as inadequate. PESCO participation does not connect to EDIP or SAFE funding. Sixty-eight projects will continue without consolidation and Ireland's projects will remain useful but marginal.

THE BOTTOM LINE

The institutional evidence of Ireland's contribution stays in the PESCO column of a spreadsheet — not embedded in the EU funding architecture. Ireland's 7 projects remain useful but marginal. The free-rider accusation survives the Presidency, and Ireland's domain-specific model is evaluated as a limitation rather than a strategy.

Recommendations

#	Action	What it locks in	For whom	By when
1	Draft 'domain excellence' pathway language for revised binding commitments	Ireland's maritime/cyber model as recognised EU defence contribution	DFA Presidency team / EEAS working group	September 2026
2	Table Presidency proposal linking PESCO participation to EDIP/SAFE preferential terms	Permanent funding pathway for domain-specific contribution	DFA / Dept of Defence	October 2026
3	Push Council recommendation to consolidate PESCO projects around capability delivery	Stronger, better-funded projects in Ireland's domains	Foreign Affairs Council	November 2026
4	Broker Ukraine's participation in PESCO maritime and cyber projects	Ireland as convener of maritime/cyber PESCO community	Dept of Defence / EEAS	December 2026

A NOTE ON METHOD

This brief assesses the PESCO Strategic Review through the lens of Ireland's strategic objective: locking in a permanent security role in its geographic domains. It does not assess PESCO's overall effectiveness or the merits of individual projects. This brief asks a narrower question: given that the strategic review is rewriting PESCO's rules, what should Ireland do about it?

Series context

Second in the Presidency Desk series — four briefs on the EU instruments Ireland must steer during its Council Presidency. Companion briefs: ReArm Europe; Maritime Surveillance Cooperation; Hybrid Threats and Cyber Defence.

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